

Meridian State University

Financial Aid and Fees Policy

Tuition, Fees, Aid Eligibility, and Refund Schedules

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Effective Date: August 1, 2026

Issuing Office: Office of the Registrar & Academic Affairs

Review Cycle: Annual

1. Overview

This policy describes how Meridian State University determines financial aid eligibility, assesses tuition and mandatory fees, and manages billing, refunds, and satisfactory academic progress requirements tied to continued aid eligibility.

2. Tuition and Mandatory Fees

Fee Category	Undergraduate (per year)	Graduate (per year)
Tuition (Resident)	\$11,400	\$13,800
Tuition (Non-Resident)	\$27,900	\$29,600
Technology Fee	\$450	\$450
Student Activity Fee	\$320	\$180
Health Services Fee	\$610	\$610
Campus Recreation Fee	\$275	\$150
Library & Learning Resources Fee	\$180	\$180

Note: Rates shown are for the current academic year and are subject to annual review by the Board of Trustees. Course-specific lab and materials fees are assessed separately.

3. Types of Financial Aid

3.1 Need-Based Aid

Determined by the Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA) and includes federal Pell Grants, Supplemental Educational Opportunity Grants, University Need Grants, and subsidized federal loans.

3.2 Merit-Based Aid

Awarded automatically upon admission based on cumulative GPA and standardized test scores for incoming freshmen, or upon transfer GPA for transfer students, ranging from \$2,000 to full-tuition Presidential Scholarships.

3.3 Departmental and Graduate Assistantships

Graduate assistantships provide a stipend and full or partial tuition remission in exchange for teaching or research service, typically 20 hours per week, and are awarded competitively by individual departments.

4. Satisfactory Academic Progress (SAP)

To retain eligibility for federal, state, and institutional aid, students must meet Satisfactory Academic Progress standards, evaluated at the end of each academic year:

- Maintain a minimum cumulative GPA of 2.0 (undergraduate) or 3.0 (graduate).

- Complete at least 67% of all attempted credit hours.
- Complete degree requirements within 150% of the published program length.

Students who fail to meet SAP standards are placed on Financial Aid Warning for one term. Continued failure results in Financial Aid Suspension, which may be appealed by submitting a SAP Appeal with supporting documentation of mitigating circumstances.

5. Billing, Payment, and Refunds

Tuition and fee statements are issued each term at least 30 days prior to the payment due date. Students may elect a five-installment payment plan through the Office of Student Accounts for a \$35 enrollment fee. Accounts not paid in full or covered by confirmed aid by the due date are assessed a 1.5% monthly late fee and may be subject to a registration hold.

5.1 Withdrawal Refund Schedule

Withdrawal Timing	Tuition Refund
Before term start	100%
Week 1	90%
Week 2	75%
Week 3	50%
Week 4	25%
After Week 4	0%

6. Return of Title IV Funds

For students who withdraw and received federal financial aid, the University calculates the amount of unearned aid that must be returned to the U.S. Department of Education in accordance with the federal Return of Title IV Funds formula, based on the percentage of the term completed. Students withdrawing after completing more than 60% of the term are considered to have earned all disbursed aid.

7. Frequently Asked Questions

When will I know my financial aid award amount?

Aid offers are typically released within 3–4 weeks of admission for students who have submitted a complete FAFSA, and are updated each term if enrollment or financial circumstances change.

What if my family's financial situation changes after I submit the FAFSA?

Students may submit a Special Circumstances Appeal with supporting documentation, which the Office of Student Financial Services reviews on a case-by-case basis outside the standard formula.

Are scholarships renewable each year?

Merit scholarships renew automatically provided the recipient maintains the minimum cumulative GPA specified in the award letter, typically 3.0, and remains enrolled full-time.

8. Related Policies and Resources

This policy should be read in conjunction with other governing University policies, including the University Catalog, the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) Notice, and any college- or department-specific handbooks that supplement, but do not contradict, the standards set out here. Where a conflict exists between this policy and a college-level document, this policy governs unless an explicit written exception has been approved by the Provost's Office.

- University Catalog (undergraduate and graduate editions), published annually
- FERPA Notice of Student Rights, available through the Office of the Registrar
- Student Handbook, distributed at orientation and available online
- College- and department-specific supplemental guidelines, where applicable

9. Contact and Further Assistance

Questions regarding the interpretation or application of this policy should be directed to the Office of Student Financial Services. Students are encouraged to reach out early in the process, as many concerns can be resolved informally before they require a formal procedure.

Contact Point	Detail
Office	Office of Student Financial Services
Email	finaid@meridianstate.edu
Phone	(555) 201-4450
Office Hours	Monday–Friday, 8:30 a.m. – 5:00 p.m.
Walk-in Location	Student Services Building, Suite 200

10. Policy Revision History

Version	Date	Summary of Changes
1.0	August 2021	Initial policy adopted by the Board of Trustees.
1.1	August 2023	Clarified procedural timelines and appeal deadlines.
2.0	August 2025	Comprehensive revision to align with updated accreditation standards.
2.1	August 2026	Minor updates for the current academic year; see effective date above.

Note: This document supersedes all prior versions upon its effective date. Archived versions are available upon request from the issuing office.